
SESSION 1A

SEEING GOD

ALAS, AND DID MY SAVIOR BLEED

Alas, and did my Savior bleed
And did my Sovereign die?
Would He devote that sacred head
For such a worm as I?

Was it for crimes that I had done
He groaned upon the tree?
Amazing pity, grace unknown
And love beyond degree

Thus might I hide my blushing face
While His dear cross appears
Dissolve my heart in thankfulness
And melt my eyes to tears

Well might the sun in darkness hide
And shut His glories in
When Christ, the mighty Maker, died
For man, the creature's, sin

But drops of grief can ne'er repay
The debt of love I owe;
Here, Lord, I give myself away,
'Tis all that I can do.

GOD'S LONGING

One of the deepest longings in the human heart is to be known as we are. When someone has a biased or distorted view of us, it's impossible to have a genuine relationship with that person. When we gain friends through wearing masks, we know that these are not true friendships.

The more we value genuine relationships, the more we will value being known as we actually are. This is God's longing: that we know him as he is.



JEREMIAH 9:23-24 (ESV)

²³Thus says the LORD: "Let not the wise man boast in his wisdom, let not the mighty man boast in his might, let not the rich man boast in his riches, ²⁴but let him who boasts boast in this, that he understands and knows me, that I am the Lord who practices steadfast love, justice, and righteousness in the earth. For in these things I delight, declares the LORD."

ISAIAH 1:2-3 (ESV)

²Hear, O heavens, and give ear, O earth;
for the Lord has spoken:

"Children have I reared and brought up,
but they have rebelled against me.

³The ox knows its owner,
and the donkey its master's crib,
but Israel does not know,
my people do not understand."

JOHN 17:3 (ESV)

³And this is eternal life, that they know you the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent.

What is God's longing according to these verses?

THE MISSING PICTURE

There are many views of God that people have picked up in our culture. The view that God is holy is often missing from that picture. Among the many aspects of who God is, his holiness must be central. To know God apart from an appreciation of his holiness leads to a distorted view of God and an unhealthy Christian life. People who don't understand that God is holy find Christianity's central message—Jesus crucified, on a bloody cross—a bit over the top. All the emphasis on sin, and the necessity of Jesus' personal sacrificial death seems a bit too much for those who do not grasp the centrality of who God is: he is holy.

The one concept, the central idea I kept meeting in Scripture, was the idea that God is holy. ... I am convinced that it is one of the most important ideas that a Christian can ever grapple with. It is basic to our whole understanding of God and of Christianity. ... The idea of holiness is so central to biblical teaching that it is said of God, "Holy is his name" (Luke 1:49). His name is holy because He is holy.¹

- R.C. Sproul, *Holiness of God*



ISAIAH 6:1–8 (ESV)

¹In the year that King Uzziah died I saw the Lord sitting upon a throne, high and lifted up; and the train of his robe filled the temple. ²Above him stood the seraphim. Each had six wings: with two he covered his face, and with two he covered his feet, and with two he flew. ³And one called to another and said:

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts;
the whole earth is full of his glory!”

⁴And the foundations of the thresholds shook at the voice of him who called, and the house was filled with smoke. ⁵And I said: “Woe is me! For I am lost; for I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips; for my eyes have seen the King, the LORD of hosts!”

⁶Then one of the seraphim flew to me, having in his hand a burning coal that he had taken with tongs from the altar. ⁷And he touched my mouth and said: “Behold, this has touched your lips; your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for.”

⁸And I heard the voice of the Lord saying, “Whom shall I send, and who will go for us?” Then I said, “Here I am! Send me.”

¹ Sproul, R.C. (2008-08-18). *Holiness of God* (p.12). Tyndale House Publishers, Inc. Kindle Edition.

On a handful of occasions the Bible repeats something to the third degree. To mention something three times in succession is to elevate it to the **superlative degree**, to attach to it emphasis of super importance. ...

Only once in sacred Scripture is an attribute of God elevated to the third degree. Only once is a characteristic of God mentioned three times in succession. The Bible says that God is holy, holy, holy. Not that He is merely holy, or even holy, holy. He is holy, holy, holy. The Bible never says that God is love, love, love; or mercy, mercy, mercy; or wrath, wrath, wrath; or justice, justice, justice. It does say that He is holy, holy, holy, that the whole earth is full of His glory.

R.C. Sproul points out there is only one attribute of God that is _____ in the Bible. (fill in the blank)

MEANING OF HOLINESS

In a sense the Bible uses holy in a way that is very closely related to God's goodness. It has been customary to define holy as "purity," free from every stain, wholly perfect and immaculate in every detail. **Purity** is the first word most of us think of when we hear the word holy. To be sure, the Bible does use the word this way. But the idea of purity or of moral perfection is at best the secondary meaning of the term in the Bible. When the seraphim sang their song, they were saying far more than that God was "purity, purity, purity." **The primary meaning of holy is "separate."** It comes from an ancient word that means "to cut," or "to separate." To translate this basic meaning into contemporary language would be to use the phrase "a cut apart." Perhaps even more accurate would be the phrase "a cut above something." When we find a garment or another piece of merchandise that is outstanding, that has a superior excellence, we use the expression that it is "a cut above the rest." God's holiness is more than just separateness. His holiness is also transcendent. The word **transcendence** means literally "to climb across." It is defined as "exceeding usual limits." To transcend is to rise above something, to go above and beyond a certain limit. When we speak of the transcendence of God, we are talking about that sense in which God is above and beyond us. Transcendence describes His supreme and absolute greatness. The word is used to describe God's relationship to the world. He is higher than the world. He has absolute power over the world. The world has no power over Him. Transcendence describes God in His consuming majesty, His exalted loftiness. It points to the infinite distance that separates Him from every creature. He is an infinite cut above everything else. When the Bible calls God holy, it means primarily that God is transcendentally separate. He is so above and beyond us that He seems almost totally foreign to us. To be holy is to be other, to be different in a special way.²

- R.C. Sproul, *Holiness of God* (emphasis added)

What is something new you learned about the meaning of God's holiness?

What thoughts and feelings do you have when you think about God as holy?

² Sproul, R.C. (2008-08-18). *Holiness of God* (p. 24-26). Tyndale House Publishers, Inc. Kindle Edition.

How strong/weak is your sense of God's holiness?

Why is it of utmost importance to understand that God is holy?

SESSION 1A QUIZ

To have a genuine relationship, we have to be _____ as we are.

According to the material, what's the significance of the seraphim calling out "Holy, holy, holy is the Lord of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!" in Isaiah 6?

- a) Threefold repetition points to the holiness of each person of the Trinity
- b) Holiness was being emphasized to superlative degree
- c) The seraphim's feet were unclean in the backdrop of God's holiness
- d) A demonstration of the proper way to enter God's Holy presence

Which is not a meaning of "holy"?

- a) Pure
- b) Separate
- c) Transcendent
- d) Just